

Executive Summary

Who are the Food Processing Workers in South Asia?

**Inputs for SAPLING High-Level Policy Dialogue:
“Unlocking Value: Advancing Food Processing for
Employment Generation and Sustainable Growth in SAR”**

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Objectives

- To profile the food processing workforce across South Asian countries, including workers' socioeconomic characteristics, education, training, and job quality.
- To identify where food processing is most relevant for jobs—by country, location, workforce segment, and occupation—so that skilling investments can be better targeted.
- To identify high-employment occupations where skilling investments could have the greatest scale, relevance, and potential impact.



Why do food processing skills matter for India?

Food processing sector is still small in employment terms, but it sits exactly where South Asia's jobs agenda needs momentum: between agriculture, manufacturing, and local non-farm opportunities.



Do not “train more workers” in general. Instead, use labor-market evidence to identify the occupations, locations, and training models most likely to support growth in food processing.



Main messages

~7m

workers in food
processing across six
countries

2.4%

average share of
total employment

42%

female workers;
higher than the rest
of labor market

54%

have secondary
education

84%

without vocational training in
countries with comparable data

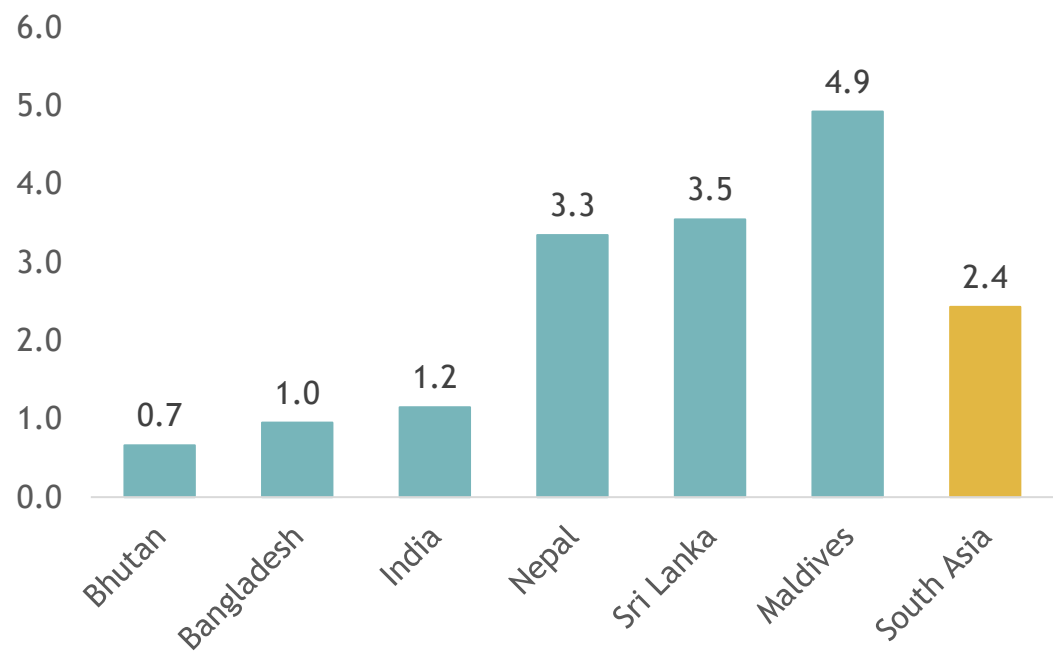
- Food processing is a small but strategically important bridge between agriculture, manufacturing, and non-farm jobs.
- The food processing workforce profile points to practical, modular training—not long academic pathways—as the core design principle.
- Training coverage is uneven across countries; outside India, vocational training remains very limited.
- Skill development strategies for food workers need to distinguish between specialization, scale, and the occupational mix.



What do the data say about scale and strategic relevance?

Food processing is small regionally, but it is a strategic platform for more and better jobs

Share of workers in food processing in South Asia, circa 2023



Food processing accounts for about 2.4 percent of total employment in South Asia.

Number of workers in food processing in South Asia, circa 2023

Country	Share of workers		Number of workers	
	Food processing	Rest of sectors	Food processing	Rest of sectors
Bhutan	0.7	99.3	1,892	283,375
Bangladesh	1.0	99.0	633,141	66,001,734
India	1.2	98.8	5,573,080	478,908,389
Nepal	3.3	96.7	225,491	6,509,213
Sri Lanka	3.5	96.5	284,121	7,725,817
Maldives	4.9	95.1	8,889	171,679
South Asia	2.4	97.6	6,726,614	559,600,207

Food processing employs around 7 million workers in the region. While still a small part of the labor market, the sector is strategically important because it sits at the intersection of agriculture, manufacturing, and jobs.



Who are food processing workers?

A workforce that calls for accessible, practical, and on-the-job training skilling

42%

female workers

60%

rural workers

26%

low-skilled
occupations

57%

medium-skilled
occupations

17%

high-skilled
occupations

17%

youth workers
(15-24 years old)

Education profile of food processing workers

Primary or less 37%

Secondary 54%

Tertiary 9%

Implication for design

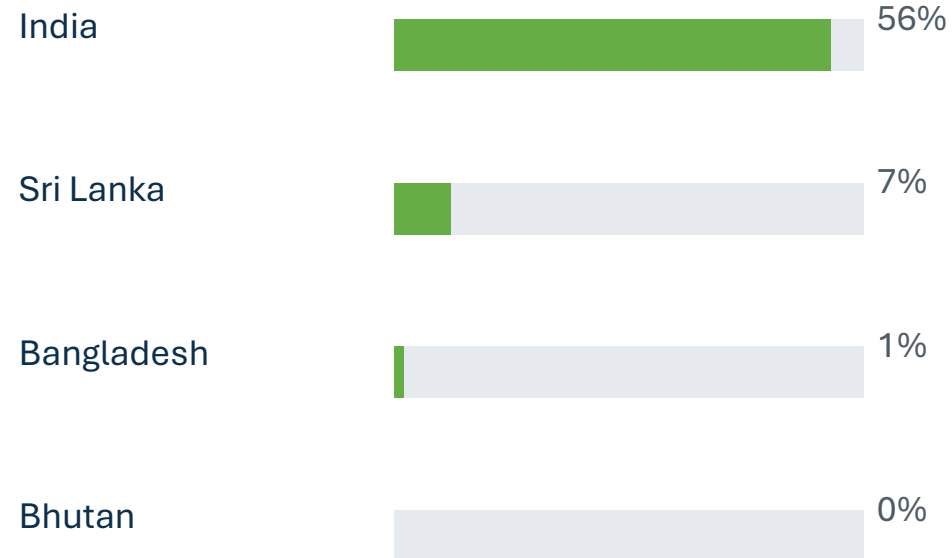
- Skills programs need to be short-cycle, practical, and accessible to workers with limited formal education.
- The broad age profile of food processing workers means both new entrants and adults already in the sector matter.
- The presence of medium- and high-skilled roles creates room for progression into technical, supervisory, and managerial jobs.



Training already matters—but coverage is uneven across countries

Vocational training is limited in most countries

Food processing workers with vocational training



84%

food processing workers do not have any vocational training in South Asia

16%

food processing workers have any vocational training in South Asia

Why this matters?

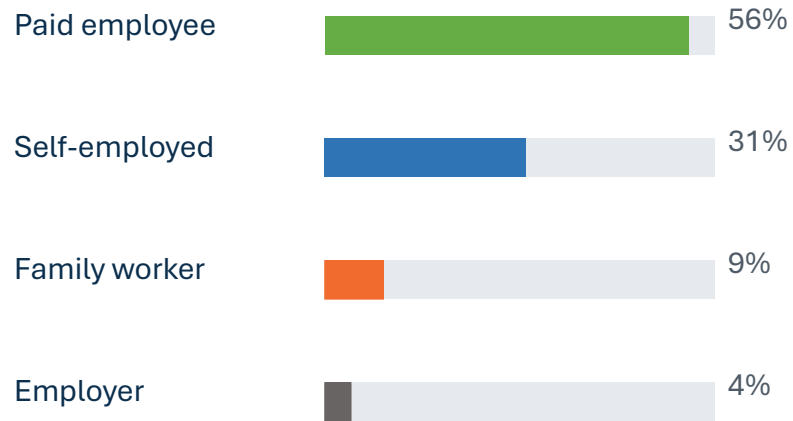
For a sector where skills are learned through practice, the low share of vocational training suggests scope to strengthen apprenticeships, employer-led training, and structured on-the-job learning.



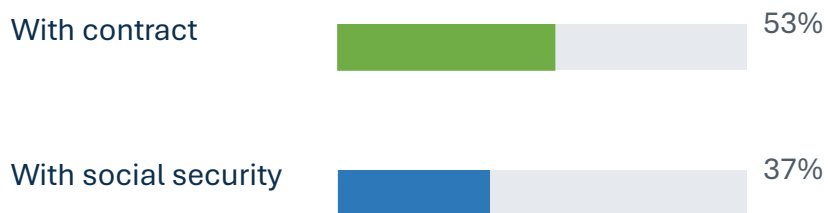
Food processing offers a more wage-oriented platform, but job quality remains uneven

The sector has more wage employment, yet contracts and social protection remain limited

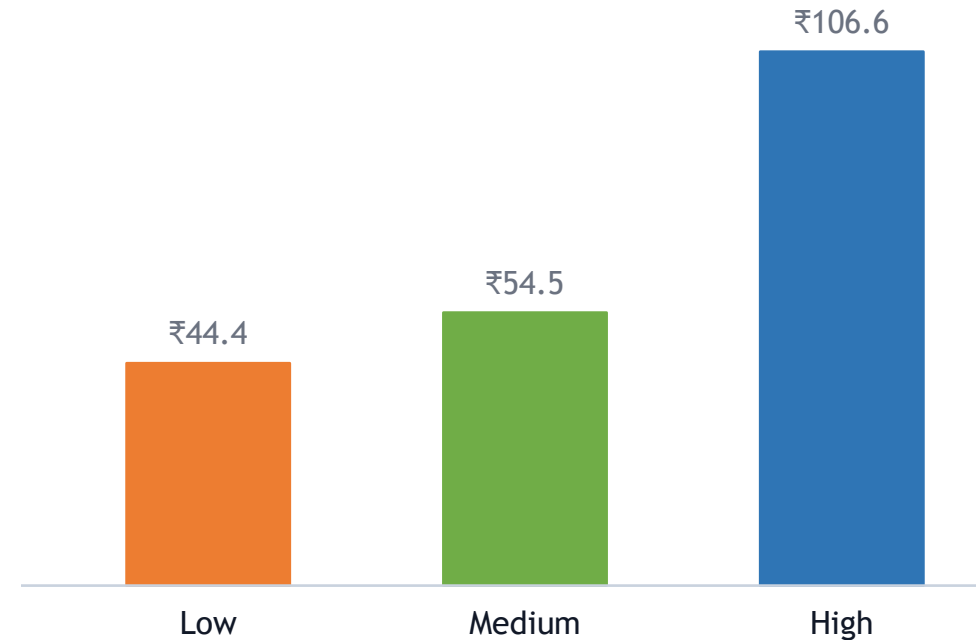
Employment status in food processing



Job quality signals



Wages rise strongly with skill level (India example)



For example, in India, average hourly wages are lower in food processing (Rs. 60.3) than in other sectors (Rs. 68.4), but higher-skilled food processing roles pay almost twice as much as medium-skilled roles.



Gujarat addendum

Food processing is smaller as a share of employment in Gujarat than in India overall

0.9%

Gujarat's food processing
share of total employment

260k

food processing workers
in Gujarat

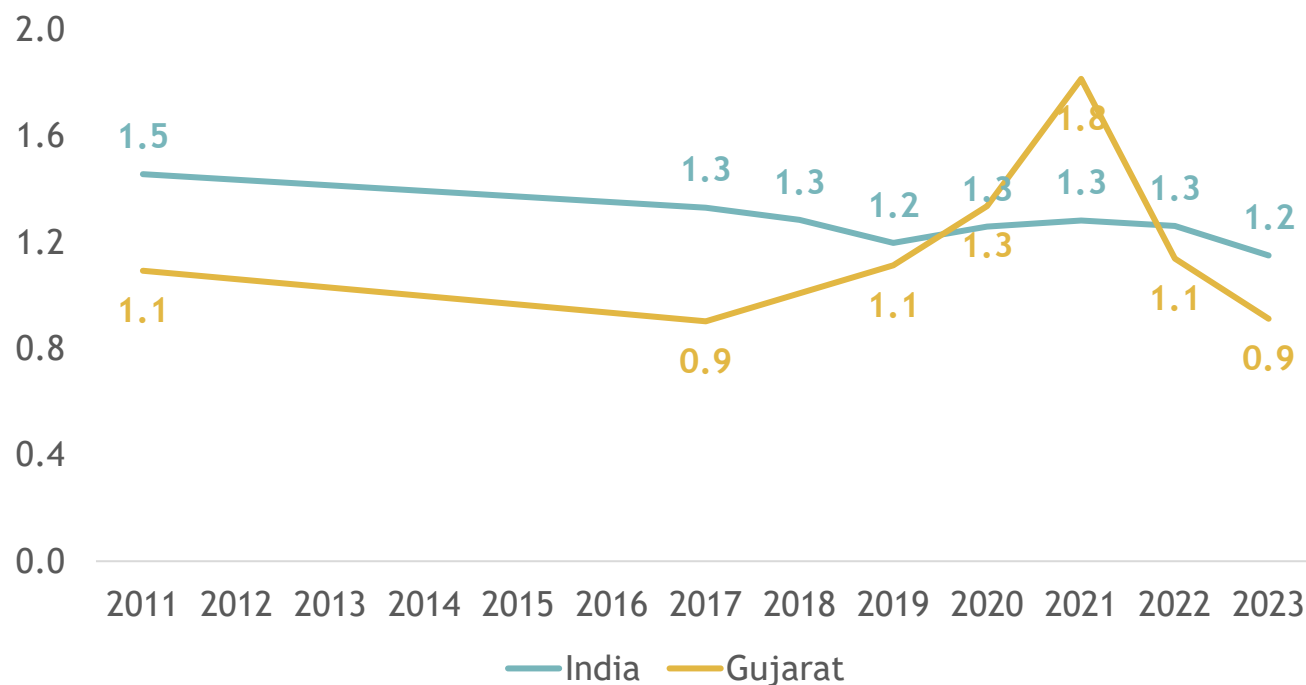
66%

Gujarat's food processing
workers living in urban areas

35%

Gujarat's food processing workers
in firms with 20+ workers

Gujarat vs India: Food processing employment over time



Main message

- Food processing employment is modest in both India and Gujarat.
- Gujarat experienced a temporary expansion between 2017 and 2021 before falling below its 2011 level by 2023.



Gujarat addendum

Food processing workforce in Gujarat versus All-India

More urban

66%

urban workers in Gujarat
40% in India

More educated

45%

secondary complete or above
39% in India

More protected

52%

with social security
30% in India

Larger firms

35%

in firms with 20+ workers
27% in India

Demographics

	India	Gujarat
Female workers	22%	27%
Youth [15–24]	13%	15%
Prime age [25–54]	73%	78%

Education

	India	Gujarat
Primary or less	37%	17%
Secondary education	49%	70%
Tertiary	14%	11%

Employment structure and job quality

	India	Gujarat
Paid employees	60%	62%
Self-employed	25%	28%
With written contract	25%	35%

Main message

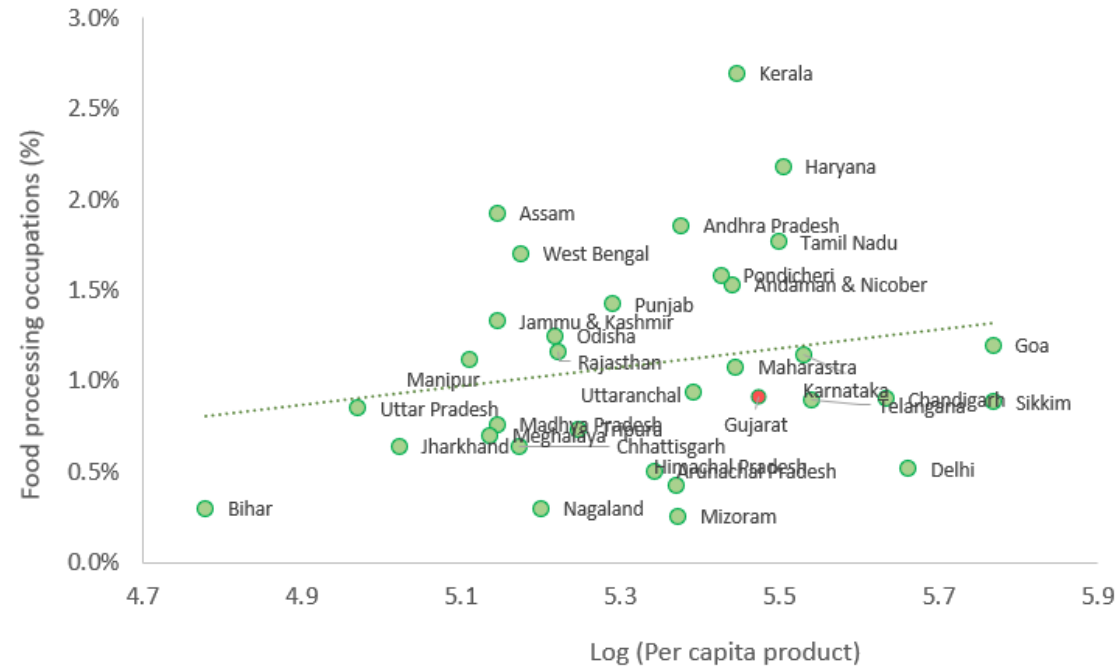
Compared with India overall, Gujarat’s food processing workforce is more urban, has more educated workers, and is somewhat more connected to larger and better-protected jobs; women’s participation is also higher, although men still account for most workers.



Gujarat addendum

Gujarat seems to have scope to expand the food processing sector relative to the state's economic potential

Food processing employment share and GDP per capita by State



Main message

Food processing is more prominent in higher-income states. Gujarat has a relatively high income per capita but is below the trend of the share of food processing employment, suggesting scope to expand the sector relative to the state's economic potential.

